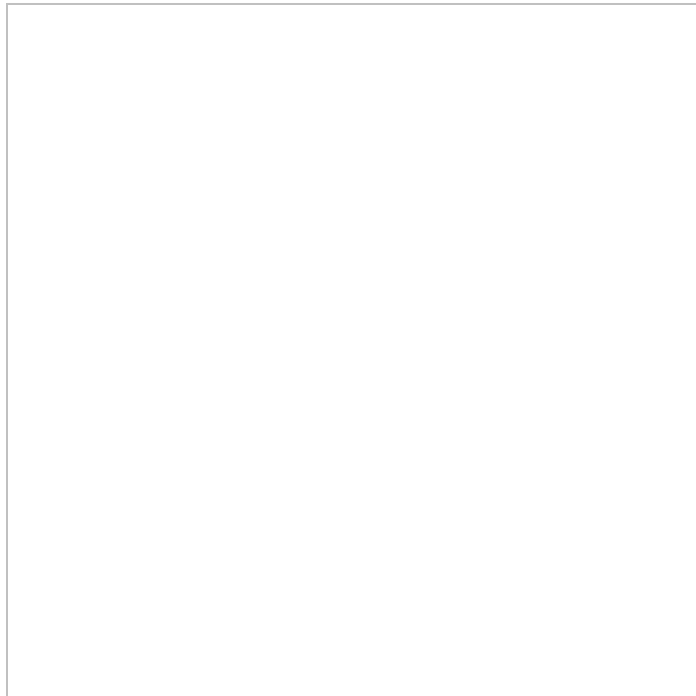




BARBARA OF PORTUGAL

Scarlatti wrote pieces for his talented keyboard student, Princess María Bárbara de Bragança.

Keyboard innovation

On a visit to Rome, Scarlatti married 16-year-old Maria Caterina Gentili in 1728. The couple had six children before she died in 1739. The composer fathered four more offspring with a second wife, Anastasia Maxarti Ximenes, the last born when he was 64.

During his years in Spain, Scarlatti wrote the 555 single-movement keyboard sonatas for which he is renowned. Mostly intended for the harpsichord, they reveled in unexpected modulation and harmonic dissonance, exploiting a wide range of innovative techniques including the crossing of hands. Many of their original effects were inspired by Spanish folk music, with